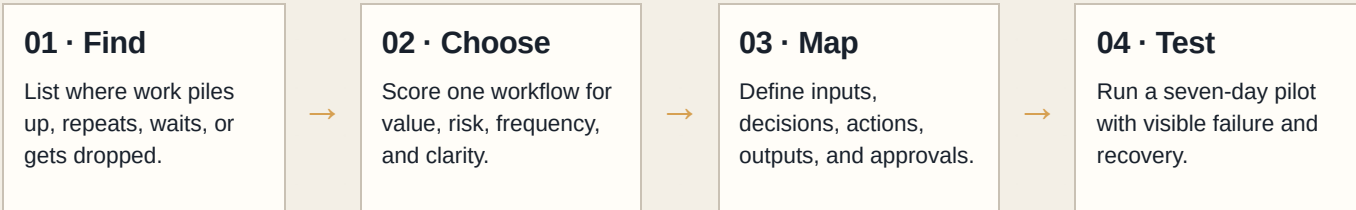


OPERATING INSTRUCTIONS

Use a pencil. Pick a real week.

The manual is designed to produce a one-page implementation brief—not another folder of AI notes.



Fast path · 45 minutes

1. Complete the Workflow Leak Inventory.
2. Score your top three candidates.
3. Complete the One-Page Build Brief.

Field path · 7 days

1. Observe the current workflow for two days.
2. Build or simulate the smallest version.
3. Run the pilot and record every exception.

One rule for the whole manual

If you cannot describe the trigger, the expected result, and the person who owns the exception, you are not ready to automate that workflow yet.

THE WORKFLOW I AM USING WHILE I READ

FIT CHECK

Does this workflow deserve a persistent operator?

Circle 1 for rarely/not true and 5 for frequently/very true.

The work repeats at least weekly.	1	2	3	4	5
It crosses two or more apps or channels.	1	2	3	4	5
Context or judgment changes the next step.	1	2	3	4	5
A missed handoff costs time, trust, or revenue.	1	2	3	4	5
The result is easy for a person to verify.	1	2	3	4	5
There is a clear owner for exceptions.	1	2	3	4	5
The process is documented or observable.	1	2	3	4	5

Mostly 1–2

Use ordinary chat or keep the process manual. Do not overbuild.

Mostly 3

A fixed automation or assisted draft may be enough.

Mostly 4–5

An operator pilot may be worth mapping—if risk is controlled.

MY CURRENT CONCLUSION

WORKSHEET 01

Where does work leak?

List repeated work without naming a technology. Use verbs: receives, checks, copies, finds, sends, schedules, reviews, uploads, reports.

REPEATED WORK	TRIGGER	WHERE IT WAITS OR BREAKS	FREQUENCY

THE LEAK PEOPLE COMPLAIN ABOUT MOST

THE LEAK I CAN VERIFY MOST EASILY

Field test: Ask two people, “What do you have to remember that the system should remember for you?” Their answers often reveal better targets than a software feature list.

WORKSHEET 02

Score the top three candidates.

Use 1–5. For **risk**, 1 means low risk and 5 means high risk. A good first lane has strong value and clarity without dangerous consequences.

CANDIDATE WORKFLOW	FREQUENCY	VALUE	CLARITY	VERIFIABLE	RISK

Green flags

- ☐ Happens often enough to learn from.
- ☐ Result can be checked quickly.
- ☐ Failure is visible and recoverable.
- ☐ One person owns the exceptions.
- ☐ Access can start read-only or draft-only.

Red flags

- ☐ Moves money or creates legal commitments.
- ☐ Requires perfect identity matching.
- ☐ Uses undocumented “tribal knowledge.”
- ☐ Failure would be silent or hard to reverse.
- ☐ Needs broad admin access on day one.

MY SELECTED FIRST WORKFLOW

WHY THIS ONE—AND WHY NOW?

DECISION GATE

Make the first lane smaller than your ambition.

A bounded workflow has a clear beginning, a clear end, and a named person who handles the exceptions.

Trigger
The observable event that starts the lane.

Approved result
The smallest useful outcome the system may produce.

Exception owner
The human who receives uncertainty or failure.

THE LANE BEGINS WHEN

THE SYSTEM MAY PREPARE OR DO

THE LANE ENDS WHEN

A HUMAN MUST APPROVE

EXCEPTIONS GO TO

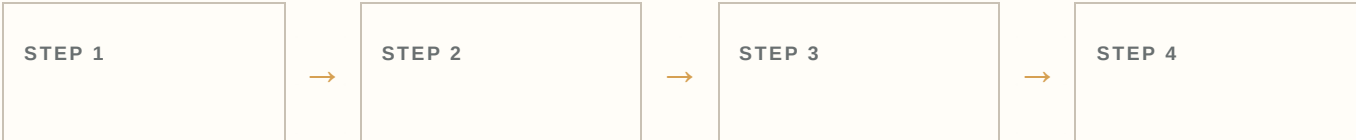
Scope test
If the workflow includes the words “and then it could also...” more than twice, split it. The purpose of the first lane is to learn safely, not to prove that AI can do everything.

WORKSHEET 03

Draw the current workflow without cleaning it up.

Include text messages, sticky notes, side conversations, duplicate entry, waiting, and the person who “just knows.”

TRIGGER



WHERE DOES IT WAIT?

WHERE IS INFORMATION RETYPED OR SEARCHED FOR?

WHO CATCHES MISTAKES NOW?

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN THEY ARE UNAVAILABLE?

Do not optimize yet. A truthful ugly map is more useful than a beautiful fictional process.

WORKSHEET 04

Design the assisted workflow.

Mark each step as **AI prepares**, **system routes**, **human approves**, or **human handles**.

STEP	OWNER	TOOL/ACCOUNT	EVIDENCE OF COMPLETION
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WHAT DISAPPEARS?

WHAT BECOMES FASTER?

WHAT STILL NEEDS JUDGMENT?

WHAT NEW FAILURE COULD APPEAR?

New risk test: If automation makes a mistake happen faster, to more customers, or without visibility, your approval or logging design is too weak.

ACCESS POSTURE

Give the workflow the smallest set of keys.

Prefer

- ☐ OAuth authorization instead of passwords.
- ☐ App-specific roles or service accounts.
- ☐ Read-only before write access.
- ☐ One folder, inbox label, calendar, or workspace.
- ☐ Revocable access with a named owner.
- ☐ Separate test and production destinations.

Avoid

- ☐ Passwords pasted into chat or worksheets.
- ☐ Full admin rights “just in case.”
- ☐ Shared personal accounts.
- ☐ Unlogged destructive actions.
- ☐ Credentials stored in prompts or documents.
- ☐ Access no one knows how to revoke.

SYSTEM	NEEDED ACCESS	OWNER	HOW REVOKED

Never write a password here

This page is for access planning. Use OAuth, administrator invites, or an approved secret manager. If setup is confusing, do it live with the account owner present.

INFORMATION BOUNDARY

Not all context belongs in the operator.

Separate what is needed to complete the workflow from what is merely available.

Needed	Helpful	Off-limits
The minimum customer, job, file, message, or schedule context required for the lane.	Context that improves quality but can be withheld during the first pilot.	Passwords, payment details, unrelated customer records, highly sensitive data, or anything outside the approved scope.

THE WORKFLOW MUST SEE

THE WORKFLOW MAY SEE LATER

THE WORKFLOW MUST NEVER RECEIVE

Retention question

For every input and output, ask: does it need to be stored, where, for how long, and who can delete it? "The AI remembers it" is not a data policy.

WHERE RECORDS WILL BE STORED AND REVIEWED

WORKSHEET 05

Write the smallest buildable brief.

WORKFLOW NAME	BUSINESS OWNER
TRIGGER	
INPUTS AND TRUSTED SOURCES	
DECISION RULES	
ALLOWED ACTIONS	HUMAN APPROVALS
COMPLETION RECORD	
EXCEPTION OWNER AND HANDOFF METHOD	
SUCCESS AFTER SEVEN DAYS MEANS	

BEFORE PRODUCTION

A demo proves the happy path. A test proves the workflow.

TEST	EXPECTED BEHAVIOR	PASS / FAIL EVIDENCE
Normal case Complete, familiar input.	Produces the correct bounded result.	
Missing information No email, file, date, or identity.	Stops or requests the missing field.	
Ambiguous identity Two similar customers/jobs.	Escalates; never guesses silently.	
Tool failure API, browser, upload, or network fails.	Records failure and preserves the work.	
Unsafe request User asks outside approved scope.	Refuses or routes to a person.	
Duplicate trigger Same job arrives twice.	Detects or safely marks the duplicate.	
Keep the evidence. Save the input, output, timestamp, approval, and error message for every test. "It seemed to work" is not a test record.		

RECOVERY PLAN

The operator should fail visibly and reversibly.

For each action, decide

- ☐ How do we know it completed?
- ☐ What does partial completion look like?
- ☐ Can the action be reversed?
- ☐ What work must be preserved?
- ☐ Who receives the alert?
- ☐ When does the system stop retrying?

A useful failure message**Job:** Smith photo delivery**Completed:** folder created, files exported**Failed:** Dropbox upload timed out**Preserved at:** local export path**Next action:** retry upload or deliver manually**THE MOST LIKELY FAILURE****WHAT MUST BE PRESERVED****HOW A PERSON RESUMES THE WORK****KILL SWITCH / DISABLE METHOD**

PREFLIGHT

Do not call it live until these are true.

- ☐ The trigger is observable and tested.
- ☐ The source of truth is named.
- ☐ Workflow scope fits in one paragraph.
- ☐ Access is minimum necessary.
- ☐ Secrets are outside prompts and documents.
- ☐ Customer-facing actions require approval.
- ☐ Every action leaves a record.
- ☐ Missing information triggers a stop.
- ☐ Ambiguous identity triggers escalation.
- ☐ Duplicate jobs are handled safely.
- ☐ Tool failure preserves partial work.
- ☐ An exception owner is available.
- ☐ The workflow can be disabled quickly.
- ☐ The seven-day measure is written down.

PILOT STARTS

PILOT ENDS

DAILY REVIEWER

EXCEPTION OWNER

THE WORKFLOW IS IMMEDIATELY DISABLED IF

Preflight principle: A narrow workflow with a clear stop condition is more professional than a broad workflow held together by optimism.

PILOT PLAN

Run the lane long enough to meet reality.

DAY	FOCUS	FIELD NOTE
1	Shadow mode: system prepares; human performs.	
2	Compare outputs and list missing context.	
3	Allow low-risk preparation automatically.	
4	Test missing, ambiguous, and duplicate inputs.	
5	Test tool failure and manual recovery.	
6	Review logs, approvals, and exception burden.	
7	Measure and decide: expand, hold, redesign, stop.	

DAILY REVIEW TIME

WHERE EVIDENCE IS STORED

Do not change five things every day. Keep a short change log. Otherwise you will not know which instruction, tool, or approval change improved the result.

PILOT SCORECARD

Measure the work—not the intelligence.

MEASURE	BEFORE	AFTER	NOTES
Average response or completion time			
Manual touches per job			
Items dropped or left waiting			
Minutes spent reviewing exceptions			
Incorrect outputs or actions			

Expand

Accuracy is stable, exceptions are manageable, and the next boundary is clear.

Hold/redesign

Value exists, but context, approval, or recovery needs work.

Stop

The process is too rare, risky, inconsistent, or expensive to supervise.

DECISION AND EVIDENCE

IF EXPANDING, THE NEXT NARROW CAPABILITY IS

FINAL WORKSHEET

One-page operator implementation brief.

BUSINESS / TEAM

WORKFLOW OWNER

THE REPEATED PROBLEM

TRIGGER → DESIRED RESULT

APPS, CHANNELS, FILES

TRUSTED SOURCE OF TRUTH

AI/SYSTEM MAY

HUMAN MUST APPROVE

EXCEPTION AND RECOVERY PATH

SEVEN-DAY SUCCESS MEASURE

KILL SWITCH / ACCESS OWNER

Ready for a map? Use “Map my first workflow” at stayautomatic.com or email this brief to kyle@stayautomatic.com.